

Cybersecurity for SME Employees: Module 1.3 - Common Cyber Threats Explained

1. Introduction

In the digital age, threats to cybersecurity are increasingly common and diverse. Understanding these threats helps employees stay alert and take proactive steps to protect their organization. This module outlines the most common cyber threats faced by individuals and businesses, particularly SMEs.

2. Common Cyber Threats

2.1 Malware

Malware is malicious software designed to damage, disrupt, or gain unauthorized access to systems. Types of malware include viruses, worms, trojans, spyware, and ransomware. Malware can be delivered via email attachments, downloads, or infected websites.

2.2 Phishing

Phishing is a form of social engineering where attackers impersonate legitimate sources to trick individuals into revealing sensitive information such as passwords or credit card numbers. Common methods include fake emails, websites, and messages.

2.3 Ransomware

Ransomware encrypts a victim's data and demands payment for its release. SMEs are frequent targets due to the likelihood they may pay to restore access quickly, especially if backups are not available.

2.4 Social Engineering

This technique manipulates individuals into performing actions or divulging confidential information. It exploits human psychology rather than technical vulnerabilities. Examples include pretexting, baiting, and tailgating.

2.5 Insider Threats

These threats come from employees or contractors with legitimate access who intentionally or unintentionally compromise security. Examples include disgruntled staff leaking data or employees falling for phishing emails.

2.6 Denial of Service (DoS) Attacks

These attacks flood a network or service with excessive traffic, making it unavailable to legitimate users. SMEs with limited infrastructure may be more vulnerable to such disruptions.

3. Conclusion

Being aware of common cyber threats is the first step toward defending against them. Employees who can recognize these threats are better equipped to prevent breaches and protect company data. The next module will focus on the specific impact of these threats on SMEs and how to build a resilient organization.